of K.S. Bajpai, political officer in Gangtok during my posting there), on the plea that a separate ordinary passport would provide him with a better cover to meet with his operational contacts in the San Francisco and Los Angeles areas.

The high commissioner was obviously asked by the MEA to explain the reason behind the issue of an ordinary passport to Shamsher without their approval. Little did Bajpai know that Shamsher had other plans to use that passport. After surrendering his diplomatic passport Shamsher had apparently obtained an immigration visa on his ordinary passport at the Canadian high commission at New Delhi. This is something Shamsher would have already arranged for with the concerned Royal Canadian Mounted Police (which at the time did the work now being done by the Canadian Security Intelligence Service) or Canadian immigration authorities at Ottawa before his departure for New Delhi. It can be safely assumed that in return for such a big favour Shamsher had compromised his position and shared some crucial information about the Department (R&AW) with the RCMP.

Upon my arrival at the Montreal-Mirabel International airport I was subjected to an ‘interview’ by the head of the immigration unit, despite the fact that my family and I held diplomatic passports, despite the fact that I was coming to join as a diplomat at the Indian high commission, and also despite a middle-level officer from the Indian high commission having come to receive us. I can only surmise that this interview was meant to probe and assess if I too could be a potential asset, willing to follow in Shamsher’s footsteps. We had to wait for about half an hour before we were finally cleared. The next morning when I called on the high commissioner, he was aware of the incident, and a note verbale was sent to the Canadian foreign office protesting the treatment meted out to me and my family at Mirabel airport.

In the aftermath of the Shamsher Singh incident, the behaviour of the high commissioner and some of the senior officers was a bit cool towards me. I, however, tried my best to improve relations with them, but as long as Bajpai remained the high commissioner I could not fully gain his trust, so very essential for the smooth functioning of the R&AW officers abroad. Things changed significantly when